A Slumber Did My Spirit Seal

The big idea

This short poem by **William Wordsworth** is one of his **"Lucy poems"**. The speaker had believed his beloved (Lucy) was beyond the reach of time. Now she is **dead** and has become one with **nature**, rolling round with the earth's daily motion along with rocks, stones and trees. The poem is about **death, loss and the unity of humans with nature**.

Summary

- **Stanza 1**: A **slumber** (a kind of dreamy unawareness) had sealed the poet's spirit; he had **no human fears**. She seemed a **thing** that could not feel the touch of **earthly years**: he thought she would never age or die.
- **Stanza 2**: Now she has **no motion and no force**; she neither hears nor sees. She is **rolled round in earth's diurnal course** (the earth's daily rotation) **with rocks, and stones, and trees**.

CONTRAST BETWEEN STANZAS

Stanza 1 = past, illusion, she seemed immortal. Stanza 2 = present, reality of death; yet she is now part of the eternal cycle of nature.

Poetic devices

Device	Example
Alliteration	"**s**lumber did my **s**pirit **s**eal"; "**r**olled **r**ound"
Metaphor	"slumber" sealing the spirit (blind belief/unawareness)

Device	Example
Euphemism	death is never named; "no motion has she now"
Imagery	"rocks, and stones, and trees"
Repetition/polysyndeton	"and stones, and trees"
Contrast	life in stanza 1, death in stanza 2

FORM

Two quatrains, rhyme scheme **ABAB**. **Diurnal** = daily.

Themes

- **Death** as a natural part of life.
- **Grief and acceptance**: the calm tone shows the poet accepting the loss.
- **Union with nature**: in death she becomes part of the earth's motion.

"SLUMBER" IS NOT DEATH

In line 1, the slumber is the **poet's** state of unawareness, not the girl's death. Her death is described in stanza 2.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What does "a slumber did my spirit seal" mean? What did the poet think of her when she was alive? How has she become part of nature? Identify alliteration.

Quick recap

- Poet believed his beloved was untouched by time.
- Now dead, she moves with the earth's daily rotation like rocks and trees.

- ABAB; alliteration, euphemism, contrast.

Practice questions

1. "A Slumber Did My Spirit Seal" was written by

   (a) Robert Frost (b) W. B. Yeats (c) William Wordsworth (d) Coates Kinney

2. In the first line, "slumber" refers to

   (a) the girl's death (b) the poet's state of unawareness or illusion (c) a night's sleep (d) a long illness

3. "She seemed a thing that could not feel the touch of earthly years" means

   (a) she was very old (b) she was a statue (c) she seemed immortal, untouched by time (d) she was always busy

4. What does "diurnal" mean?

   (a) Yearly (b) Weekly (c) Nightly (d) Daily

5. How is the dead girl described in stanza 2?

   (a) She has no motion or force; she neither hears nor sees (b) She is sleeping peacefully in her bed (c) She is walking in the woods (d) She has become a star

6. The rhyme scheme of each stanza is

   (a) AABB (b) ABCB (c) ABAB (d) ABAAB

7. How does the poet describe the girl in the two stanzas?

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. c 4. d 5. a 6. c 7. see notes